

- 1) A SUCS customer service philosophy must be delivered by your employees.
- 2) Spectacular product features can't overcome poor service.

First, employees must deliver your customer service philosophy. Your people are ambassadors of your business and they communicate your vision. Essentially, they're business chauffeurs, and if they're reckless, your vision is destroyed. *Your employees drive the public's perception of your company.*

Was it the Venetian's policy to treat me with such disrespect and disinterest? Doubtful. The failure was in the communication lines from management to employee. Not just one employee, but several. You can't be driving the ship all day. Your employees carry the water buckets, and if they aren't ordained in service, they hijack business and create liabilities. Customer service philosophy is irrelevant if employees don't translate that philosophy into frontline action.

The second lesson is this: No amount of spectacular product features, such as great technology (snazzy Web sites) or great architecture (lavishly appointed hotels) can compensate for poor customer service. Despite the Venetian's billion-dollar appearance, the marble floors and the ornate columns, their customer service sucked. Yet, at the Rio Hotel, customer service was excellent, which translated into a great experience, despite the hotel's dated building.

This incongruity represents a one-way street: Fanatical customer service—service that SUCS—can help compensate for shortcomings, but fanatical features cannot compensate for poor customer service, or poor human interaction. The Venetian's floor could have been made of solid gold. It wouldn't have mattered. *Nothing overcomes poor human experiences!*

You could own the best hotel in the world located on the best beach in California, but if customers are treated like inconveniences and requests go unfulfilled, they won't return. Exponential business growth is fueled by fanatical customer service, and your frontline employees must share your vision. It doesn't come from boastful mission statements plastered on the CEO's office wall.

CHAPTER SUMMARY: FASTLANE DISTINCTIONS

- A business partnership is as important as a marriage.
- A good accountant and attorney will save you thousands, perhaps millions.
- Accountants and attorneys have the keys to your castle; make sure you trust them fully because they have the power to right or wrong you.
- Unmitigated trust exposes you to unmitigated risk.
- Unverified trust can lead to uncontrollable consequences.
- Your employees communicate the public's perception of your company.
- Fanatical customer service can overcome shortcomings, but fanatical features can't overcome poor customer service.
- Customer service philosophy is delivered from human interactions—not ambitious mission statements on a wall plaque in the CEO's office.